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The new laws that will streamline rebuilding efforts following devastating LA fires

October 31, 2025 | CALO NEWS (Los Angeles, CA)
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OpenURL Link

The California State Legislature and Governor Gavin Newsom have passed dozens of laws aimed at fast-tracking rebuilding efforts for those impacted by the historic fires in Los Angeles earlier this year.

Nine months after the Palisades and Eaton fires ripped through L.A., Newsom signed a comprehensive package of bills targeted at streamlining rebuilding and permitting, new protections for homeowners and tenants, as well as property tax relief and financial support, among other things.

"While it's been nine months since these firestorms struck Los Angeles, the destruction and devastation left behind is still fresh for thousands of survivors and remains a constant reminder that we have more to do to support our fellow Californians," said Newsom in a prepared statement. He continued, "together with the legislature, we're putting the lessons we learned in January into action and delivering the most significant upgrade to California's disaster response and recovery efforts in years - supporting wildfire survivors now and in the future."

The fires

The month of January brought forth a continuous stream of wildfires, many starting on the same day and taking several days to contain.

The Eaton fire began on Jan. 7 in Eaton Canyon in the San Gabriel Mountains and was driven by strong Santa Ana winds into foothill communities, particularly the predominantly Black neighborhood of Altadena. Latinos made up about 27% of the affected population in the Eaton fire.

The Palisades fire also began on Jan. 7, burning through the Santa Monica Mountains of L.A. County and hitting large areas of the Pacific Palisades, Topanga and Malibu. Latinos made up approximately 7% of the population affected by this fire.

Less talked about, the Hurst fire broke out in the Sylmar area of L.A. County and affected areas including the Santa Clarita Valley, Pacoima and San Fernando.

Despite overall making up 23% of the population affected by the Eaton, Palisades and Hurst fires, Latinos represented 36% of all workers in those zones, causing thousands to experience both home and job loss.

Rebuilding laws

Newsom signed into law the following bills aimed at protecting homeowners and tenants after the disaster:

AB 299: Allows people who have been displaced by disasters to stay in short-term rentals, hotels or motels without being considered tenants. By not allowing for a landlord-tenant relationship, occupants would have more protections and stability if staying for longer than 30 days. Principal author is Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino);SB 610: Expands disaster protections for tenants, mobile home residents and borrowers. Landlords must remove debris and maintain habitability, while tenants retain pre-disaster rents. Mobile home residents will be entitled to rent refunds and relief during evacuations, and relocation benefits if parks close. Principal author is Sen. Sasha Pérez (D-Pasadena); andAB 851: Protects homeowners from "predatory buyers" offering unsolicited real estate purchase offers in specific zip codes affected by fires in L.A. and Ventura Counties until Jan. 1, 2027. Authored by Assembly Member Tina McKinnor (D-Inglewood).

These bills will provide property tax relief to wildfire survivors:

AB 245: Allows additional time to rebuild homes or businesses without worrying about a property tax increase. Authored by Assembly Member Mike Gipson (D-Gardena);SB 293: Gives homeowners more time to update property ownership records after a disaster to avoid tax penalties. Authored by Pérez (D-Pasadena); andSB 663: Allows flexible deadlines and special exemptions during reassessment of damaged property. The principal author is Senator Ben Allen (D-El Segundo).

The following bills are targeted at streamlining the rebuilding process:

AB 462: Requires decisions on coastal permits within 60 days, streamlining the process for accessory dwelling units (ADUs) in the Coastal Zone. Principal author is Assembly Member Josh Lowenthal (D-Long Beach);AB 818: Expedites local permitting for disaster-rebuild homes and temporary housing. Residents can place manufactured homes, modular homes or detached ADUs on private lots during reconstruction and local governments must process these permit applications within 10 business days. Authored by Assembly Member Anamarie Avila Farias (D-Concord); andSB 676: Expedites administrative and judicial review procedures under the California Environmental Quality Act (CEQA) for projects that deal with wildfire-damaged property or facilities located in an area declared a state of emergency by the governor. The principal author is Senator Monique Limón (D-Santa Barbara).

The governor also signed bills aimed at insurers, making it easier for homeowners and small businesses to rebuild:

SB 495: Mandates insurers to offer 60% of personal property coverage, up to $350,000, without an itemized claim for total home losses due to a declared disaster. It also extends the proof of loss deadline from 60 to 100 days. Authored by Allen (D-El Segundo);SB 547: Insurers cannot cancel or refuse to renew commercial property policies for one year after a state of emergency declaration if the property is in a wildfire zone or adjacent ZIP code. Authored by Pérez (D-Pasadena).

Newsom also recently announced the CalAssist Mortgage Fund, a program that provides grants for three months' worth of mortgage payments, will be increasing its income limits by $70,000.

The state program is administered through the California Housing Finance Agency and was expanded specifically to allow more survivors of the L.A. fires to qualify.

In order to be eligible, homeowners must have experienced their primary residence being destroyed or severely damaged by a disaster that occurred between Jan. 1, 2023, and Jan. 8, 2025. The household income limit for L.A. County has been raised to $211,050.

The funds are paid directly to mortgage servicers and it is free to apply here. For information on CalAssist income limits for all California counties, click here.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Valadez, A. (2025, October 31). The new laws that will streamline rebuilding efforts following devastating LA fires*CALO NEWS (Los Angeles, CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A417AFB66AC11F8.